The EDM Research Manifesto & Methodology Framework

Independent Airdrop Research & Legitimacy Assessment

"Only the Legit, Never the Hype"

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Lead Researcher: Kyle Walter

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Foreword

The crypto space is not as it was in its inception; scams, hype, rugpulls are now everywhere. And airdrops? Worse. Telegram has become a graveyard for dead projects. Other projects ghost before TGE. The ones that list lose up to 90% of initial/peak value within 3 months. The classic crypto timetable.

But who gets to suffer for the airdrop's performance? The airdrop farmers! Especially those who gave their all in the project. Referring. Farming. Spamming. Even depositing sometimes. They believed it would hit the moon.. They trusted the protocols because of their community responsiveness, informality and funding. Unfortunately, their faith was unfounded and without substance. Many end up receiving pennies. Others are unduly disqualified. Some don't even hear of the project again (the project ghosts them). This scam is so common in the crypto space as of 2026 that many farmers scammed of their time and devoted efforts have sworn to never participate in anything called crypto airdrops.

Projects like Tapswap, Paws, Hamster Kombat, Pixelverse, Scroll, and zkLend exemplify these failures.

Perhaps, there is something we're missing. Maybe there's a fault on our side. Come to think of it, did we really do our own research? DYOR (Do Your Own Research) is the most common rule in airdrop participation, yet many of us gloss over this fundamental requirement. No wonder we engaged with scam and didn't know. No wonder we expected 100x hits but value stayed below floor price. It's time to start taking independent verification seriously.

Now let's get to the real questions: Yes, DYOR must be done to be able to make better informed decisions and increase (not guarantee) your chance of securing rewards and profit.

However, are you sure you really know how to DYOR? Were you taught how to? Or were you vaguely instructed to "conduct independent verification before participation"? This is a big problem because thorough and high quality DYOR would require specialised knowledge and much analysis time (up to 3hrs). How

then would individuals doing airdrops as side-job find enough time to analyse the numerous amount of airdrops they do?

There is, however, a solution. We didn't tell you the problems to make you aware and stranded. We have proposed a solution to cater to this exact issue: Unlike aggregators that prioritize volume and hype, we provide independent legitimacy audits using a rigorous 5-pillar framework and scoring system to present to you only the most credible and time-worthy airdrops so you don't have to waste time and efforts on scams and dead projects. More information about us is available in the following pages.

The EquiDrop Maestros: Introduction

Our title perfectly describes all about us. The EDM is an independent initiative envisioned to be run by Maestros who will demonstrate professional commitment in filtering out scam from the airdrop space. We prioritise legitimacy, transparency and accountability of projects by employing an elite research framework which consists of strict requirements projects are weighed against to prove their level of legitimacy. We also use ratings for quick evaluation of the project and the rating system is dependent on our ever evolving research framework.

Why EDM Exists

Our purpose is simple: prioritise legitimacy over hype, equity over misconduct. We are here for those airdrop degens who are tired of the plaguing scams and dead "opportunities" filling the web3.

We are not simply an airdrop aggregator as the likes of Airdrops.io and Airdrop Detective; we position ourselves as professional independent airdrop auditors. They post airdrops; We vet them. The difference is clear. They are not our competitors. We work hand-in-hand to make the crypto space a healthier safer and more informed space both for hype-driven farmers and skeptical risk-evaluating ones.

Aside providing thoroughly vetted airdrop analysis, we also have a second mission: The EquiDrop Maestros is currently operated solely by pseudonymous

developer Kyle Walter, however we envision a future where EDM becomes a decentralized community where airdrop farmers (whom we call "Maestros") and crypto enthusiasts all over the globe actively contribute to the operations and effectiveness of this service. This is our true primary goal.

And to reach that milestone, I will start the service privately, then introduce educating programs in the near future so as to empower farmers to develop mid-to-professional level airdrop auditing skills, which would enable them conduct DYOR with confidence and accuracy. We launched in January 2026. The work has only begun.

The Equitable Distribution Model: Our 5-Pillar Framework

To address these systemic issues, we compiled a research model consisting of strict legitimacy requirements, which we call **"The Equitable Distribution Model"**.

Below are the five pillars:

A. Team & Project Credibility

- Verifiable team identities and track record
- Legal entity registration, jurisdiction and compliance clarity
- Active communication and criticism handling (complaints, controversies)
- Accessible and clear documentation (legal, ToS, whitepaper, roadmap)
- Roadmap promises vs. execution history

Why It Matters:

A transparent and accountable team is foundational to trust. Anonymous or unverifiable teams are the strongest predictors of scams, as they lack accountability. Legal registration and compliance signal commitment to regulatory standards, while clear documentation and roadmap adherence demonstrate seriousness and reliability. Projects that ignore criticism or fail to deliver on promises risk eroding community trust and long-term viability.

B. Tokenomics & Distribution Design

- Supply mechanics and allocation breakdown
- Token utility and long-term economic sustainability
- Vesting amounts and schedules for insiders and emission/burn mechanics
- Alignment of incentives between team and community
- Protocol revenue and value accrual to holders
- Token necessity in ecosystem (beyond governance)

Why It Matters:

Tokenomics define a project's economic sustainability and fairness. Poorly structured allocations or vesting schedules enable insider exploitation. Sustainable token utility and value accrual mechanisms are critical to ensuring the ecosystem thrives beyond speculative hype.

C. Technical & Product Fundamentals

- Security and smart contracts audits by reputable firms
- Infrastructure integrations and ecosystem interoperability
- Technical innovation, stage of working product (MVP, beta, mainnet) and genuine differentiation
- GitHub activity including commit frequency, contributor diversity, and codebase transparency

Why It Matters:

Technical execution separates credible projects from vaporware. Audited smart contracts and active development (evidenced by GitHub activity) prove the team is building a functional product not just marketing an idea. Interoperability and genuine innovation address real user needs, while a clear product roadmap demonstrates progress toward mainstream adoption.

D. Airdrop Distribution Mechanics

- Clear eligibility criteria and timeline
- Transparency in airdrop type, structure, and timeline

- Strong sybil protection and KYC/AML requirements
- Token contract details and on-chain metrics
- Participation barriers (deposits, referrals, social tasks, purchases)

Why It Matters:

Fair and transparent distribution mechanics ensure the airdrop rewards genuine participants, not sybil attackers or paid farmers. Ambiguous criteria or excessive barriers (e.g., mandatory deposits) risk alienating legitimate users or enabling exploitation. Clear tokenomics and on-chain transparency allow participants to independently verify legitimacy before investing time or resources.

E. Secondary/Supporting Factors

- Reputable VC backing and media coverage
- Community size, engagement authenticity and adoption
- Market need and competitive positioning
- Clearly articulated goals (narrative clarity) and project vision
- On-chain metrics and network health
- Exchange partnerships and listings

Why It Matters:

External validation (e.g., VC backing, exchange listings) and organic community growth signal market confidence, while on-chain metrics prove real usage. Without demonstrated adoption or a clear market need, even technically sound projects may fail to sustain value. Narrative clarity and competitive positioning help distinguish viable solutions from redundant or predatory offerings.

Each pillar score (0.0–1.0) is calculated as the average of its subcriteria, with equal weighting unless specified in our forthcoming scoring rubric. The total score is the sum of all five pillars (maximum 5.0). Our scoring rubric for each pillar is currently dynamic and still in development. A detailed and stable rating system will be published in time.

How to Interpret Our Ratings (X.X/5)

Score	Rating
5.0/5.0	**Exceptional Legitimacy**
4.0–4.9/5.0	**Strong Legitimacy**
3.0–3.9/5.0	**Moderate Legitimacy**
2.0–2.9/5.0	**Significant Concerns**
1.0–1.9/5.0	**Critical Red Flags**
2.0/5 (Capped)	**Disqualified**

5.0/5.0 — Exceptional Legitimacy
Rare. Outstanding across all criteria: transparent team, sustainable tokenomics, working product, fair distribution, strong backing. Still requires your own research, but passes our strictest standards.

4.0-4.9/5.0 — Strong Legitimacy
Solid fundamentals with minor concerns. Worth serious consideration for informed participants. May have one weak area but is overall trustworthy.

3.0-3.9/5.0 — Moderate Legitimacy
Mixed positioning with notable weaknesses. Requires extra caution and deeper personal research. Not recommended for risk-averse users.

2.0-2.9/5.0 — Significant Concerns
Multiple red flags identified. High-risk profile. Only for experienced users who understand they might lose everything.

1.0-1.9/5.0 — Critical Red Flags
Major legitimacy failures. Likely scam, regulatory risk, or fundamentally flawed. Participate at your own risk.

2.0/5 (Capped) — Disqualified
Regardless of other scores, automatic disqualifier applies. Proceed with caution or avoid entirely.

Severe Disqualifiers (Capped Score: 2.0/5)

While we have a professional scoring system in place, some red flags/flaws are so severe that they cap the maximum possible rating at 2.0/5.0, regardless of other strengths the project may hold:

- Anonymous team with zero accountability mechanisms
- Scam/Impersonating projects or teams
- No working product + vague/inaccessible roadmap
- Demonstrably unsustainable tokenomics structure or product-market fit absence
- Critical unresolved smart contract risks
- Obvious Ponzi/pyramid scheme mechanics
- Promotional and get rich quick language without realistic & clear utility

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Research Framework & Workflow

How We Source Airdrops

We monitor:

- Top tier airdrop aggregators
- Numerous crypto communities
- Official project announcements

Our Research Workflow

1. **Retrieval:** Receiving alerts on live airdrops
2. **Basic Screening:** AI tools (Claude, Grok, GPT, etc) run quick basic eligibility/transparency scan
3. **Manual Dive:** Kyle Walter runs deep review of qualified projects, assessing legitimacy status
4. **Scoring:** Assigning ratings for each pillar and totalling score
5. **Publication:** Findings are compiled with full transparency about methodology

6. **Monitoring:** We continually track projects for developments until airdrop ends

Our Credibility Commitment

- Every airdrop undergoes a minimum 3-day review period before publication
- Our AI research prompts are publicly available on GitHub
- We monitor projects and update ratings when new findings and changes occur
- No project pays for coverage; our independence is non-negotiable.

Competitive Landscape

While we publish assigned ratings and detailed "How to Join Airdrop" walkthroughs within our analysis, we are not direct competitors with established aggregators such as Airdrop Alert or Airdrop Ninja. The major distinction between us and the afore mentioned is our objective. They serve a different mandate: aggregation and volume. We serve a different need — legitimacy and depth.

The EquiDrop Maestros is occupying a position that no other service currently fills: independent, framework-driven legitimacy auditing of crypto airdrops. We do not serve everyone: our target audience are those who would appreciate legitimate and innovative projects. That said, hype and volume-driven degens may not fully regard our mandate.

Our motto says it all: ***Legitimacy Over Hype***

Monetization Model

We accept no payments from projects or individuals—no ads, no sponsored content, no referral commissions. How then do we sustain operations? By:

- Participating in airdrops we evaluate, alongside the community
- Voluntary unsolicited donations (no solicitation from us)

This model keeps us focused on our mission: identifying legit projects while avoiding conflicts of interest.

Given the enormous volume of airdrop campaigns and the speedy rate at which more airdrops are announced, sole operator Kyle Walter currently uses a triage style of research. This selective-research approach is only temporary and increases our own likelihood of participating in the airdrops we list, thus improving our monitoring efficiency and speed.

That said, capacity permitting, any community member may still request a private research report through our contact channels. Requests are handled in turn, and projects that meet our research threshold will be published on the platform. Two contact channels are currently available: Substack DM/comments and email.

Our Standards

- Independence
- Effort Protection
- Structured Research
- Education
- Free of Charge

Our Platforms

- 📝 **Substack:** @equidropmaestros
- 💻 **GitHub:** @kylewalter101
- 📧 **Email:** kylework101@proton.me
- 🌐 **Decentralized socials:** *coming soon*
- 🔗 **Official Sites:** *coming soon*

> *Telegram and Facebook are no longer maintained due to censorship and regulatory issues.*

Disclaimers

We reiterate that we are research publishers and educators not financial advisors. Our analysis and rating does not constitute financial advice. All analysis report provided are sourced from publicly available data. All readers must conduct their own due diligence, using our analysis as a supplementary resource and cross-referencing with other sources. It is good to remember that crypto participation carries inherent risk. Teams and projects can change terms and protocols anytime. Stay sharp. Stay safe. DYOR.

Additional Important Note:

We do not guarantee success or profit potential from any airdrop we list or rate (especially highly). Let us be clear—we publish and rate drops according to our research model, but ultimately, our assessment as independent researchers (and not insiders) is limited to the current legitimacy of the project, not its future performance. Although our analysis and scoring may be confident or high, you must keep in mind that projects can change terms and eligibility requirements anytime. And doing so would render our assessment obsolete and highly unfit for decision-making. Also, legitimate projects and platforms audited by top tier platforms have failed in the past (eg FTX, Terra Luna).

Our system only increases your success rate by helping you focus on credible opportunities. You are still, however required to perform independent evaluation before participating.

About Kyle Walter

I am Kyle Walter, a pseudonymous crypto enthusiast with several years of experience as an airdrop farmer. I have seen countless scams. Ghostings before TGE. And I've lost money in few cases because of sentiment. You can now understand my reason for creating EDM.

Additionally, I am aware of the importance of transparency and the drawback, using a pseudonymous identity can pose to some. However I also acknowledge that it is not uncommon for doxxed identities to be harassed, undervalued or attacked especially during controversial events, thus I chose pseudonymity. My accountability is my research and communication reach not my face.

> **The EquiDrop Maestros**
> *Only the Legit, Never the Hype.*

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Research Standards Subject to Continuous Improvement

Always conduct independent verification before participating in any airdrop.